At the same time, it is not just its relative weakness but also its international assertiveness which set the Russian Federation apart from the others. Russia is now digging its heels into the first year of a conflict over influence in Ukraine. The crisis, fruit of a diplomatic slide which has been in the making for years, is likely to dominate European security for decades. Russia, today, constitutes the first line of inter-imperial rivalries in the system between emerging powers, on the one hand, and Europe, the US and its allies, on the other. Its role in the BRICS group thus gains relevance, not just for itself but in terms of the key questions of power relations in the system it raises. What follows is an attempt to frame and tentatively answer these questions as well as offer an examination of something we could call the 'Eurasian' challenge, both galvanising and explaining some of the specificities of Russian neoliberal imperialism after the collapse of the Soviet Union and particularly under Putin.

BRICS or BICS?

Can Russia legitimately be called a BRICS country, then? Does it offer the hallmarks of an emerging power, as the fulfilment of its BRICS potential should imply? Commentary and tentative answers to these questions can lead to some confusion, since they vary widely depending on the specific year in which they are formulated (betraying, I think, a slight anxiety about the end of the Cold War). I come back to the volatile evolution of Russian capitalism since 1991 below, but its ups and downs have frequently altered the perceptions of Russian power and wealth. In the mid-2000s, for instance, and although Russia had already left behind the worst of the disastrous 1990s, the country seemed to fall short of its BRICS status: 'Russia', wrote S Neil Macfarlane in 2005, 'is more properly seen as a state which has recently experienced substantial damage and is attempting to stop the bleeding' (2006:43). Macfarlane, using data from 2004, rightly pointed out that Russia's baseline growth (filtering out the increase in international hydrocarbon prices) was still very low, and that in GDP terms, Russia was more commensurable to Holland, representing only a third of the size of the Chinese economy. But already in 2007, as the growth trends of the early 2000s seemed to intensify, the European Council on Foreign Relations argued that Russia had clearly become a rising power (Leonard and Popescu 2007). Not only observers but also the Russian elite would soon become infused with the same enthusiasm; and suddenly the prospects blackened once again after 2008–9, with the turbulence induced by the war in South Ossetia, the burst of the commodity boom, and the arrival of the global economic downturn in Russia. In 2012, Russia was certified as 'post-BRIC' (Judah, Kobzova and Popescu 2011). The outspoken